18 Job · Job

1 There was a man in the land of Uz whose name was Job. And this man was blameless and upright, fearing God and shunning evil.
[2] He had seven sons and three daughters,
[3] and he owned 7,000 sheep, 3,000 camels, 500 yoke of oxen, 500 female donkeys, and a very large number of servants. Job was the greatest man of all the people of the East.
[4] Job's sons would take turns holding feasts in their homes, and they would invite their three sisters to eat and drink with them.
[5] And when the days of feasting were over, Job would send for his children to purify them, rising early in the morning to offer burnt offerings for all of them. For Job thought, "Perhaps my children have sinned and cursed God in their hearts." This was Job's regular practice.
[6] One day the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came with them.
[7] "Where have you come from?" said the LORD to Satan. "From roaming through the earth," he replied, "and walking back and forth in it."
[8] Then the LORD said to Satan, "Have you considered My servant Job? For there is no one on earth like him, a man who is blameless and upright, who fears God and shuns evil."
[9] Satan answered the LORD, "Does Job fear God for nothing?"
[10] Have You not placed a hedge on every side around him and his household and all that he owns? You have blessed the work of his hands, and his possessions have increased in the land.
[11] "But stretch out Your hand and strike all that he has, and he will surely curse You to Your face."
[12] "Very well," said the LORD to Satan. "Everything he has is in your hands, but you must not lay a hand on the man himself." Then Satan went out from the presence of the LORD.
[13] One day, while Job's sons and daughters were eating and drinking wine in their oldest brother's house,
[14] a messenger came and reported to Job: "While the oxen were plowing and the donkeys were grazing nearby,"
[15] "the Sabeans swooped down and took them away. They put the servants to the sword, and I alone have escaped to tell you!"
[16] While he was still speaking, another messenger came and reported: "The fire of God fell from heaven. It burned and consumed the sheep and the servants, and I alone have escaped to tell you!"
[17] While he was still speaking, another messenger came and reported: "The Chaldeans formed three bands, raided the camels, and took them away. They put the servants to the sword, and I alone have escaped to tell you!"
[18] While he was still speaking, another messenger came and reported: "Your sons and daughters were eating and drinking wine in their oldest brother's house,"
[19] "when suddenly a mighty wind swept in from the desert and struck the four corners of the house. It collapsed on the young people and they are dead, and I alone have escaped to tell you!"
[20] Then Job stood up, tore his robe, and shaved his head. He fell to the ground and worshiped,
[21] saying: "Naked I came from my mother's womb, and naked I will return. The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away. Blessed be the name of the LORD."
[22] In all this, Job did not sin or charge God with wrongdoing.

2 On another day the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came with them to present himself before Him.
[2] "Where have you come from?" said the LORD to Satan. "From roaming through the earth," he replied, "and walking back and forth in it."
[3] Then the LORD said to Satan, "Have you considered My servant Job? For there is no one on earth like him, a man who is blameless and upright, who fears God and shuns evil. He still retains his integrity, even though you incited Me against him to ruin him without cause."
[4] "Skin for skin!" Satan replied. "A man will give up all he owns in exchange for his life."
[5] "But stretch out Your hand and strike his flesh and bones, and he will surely curse You to Your face."
[6] "Very well," said the LORD to Satan. "He is in your hands, but you must spare his life."
[7] So Satan went out from the presence of the LORD and infected Job with terrible boils from the soles of his feet to the crown of his head.
[8] And Job took a piece of broken pottery to scrape himself as he sat among the ashes.
[9] Then Job's wife said to him, "Do you still retain your integrity? Curse God and die!"
[10] "You speak as a foolish woman speaks," he told her. "Should we accept from God only good and not adversity?" In all this, Job did not sin in what he said.
[11] Now when Job's three friends—Eliphaz the Temanite, Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophar the Naamathite—heard about all this adversity that had come upon him, each of them came from his home, and they met together to go and sympathize with Job and comfort him.
[12] When they lifted up their eyes from afar, they could barely recognize Job. They began to weep aloud, and each man tore his robe and threw dust in the air over his head.
[13] Then they sat on the ground with him for seven days and seven nights, but no one spoke a word to him because they saw how intense his suffering was.

3 After this, Job opened his mouth and cursed the day of his birth.
[2] And this is what he said:
[3] "May the day of my birth perish, and the night it was said, 'A boy is conceived.'"
[4] If only that day had turned to darkness! May God above disregard it; may no light shine upon it.
[5] May darkness and gloom reclaim it, and a cloud settle over it; may the blackness of the day overwhelm it.
[6] If only darkness had taken that night away! May it not appear among the days of the year; may it never be entered in any of the months.
[7] Behold, may that night be barren; may no joyful voice come into it.
[8] May it be cursed by those who curse the day— those prepared to rouse Leviathan.
[9] May its morning stars grow dark; may it wait in vain for daylight; may it not see the breaking of dawn.
[10] For that night did not shut the doors of the womb to hide the sorrow from my eyes.
[11] Why did I not perish at birth; why did I not die as I came from the womb?
[12] Why were there knees to receive me, and breasts that I should be nursed?
[13] For now I would be lying down in peace; I would be asleep and at rest
[14] with kings and counselors of the earth, who built for themselves cities now in ruins,
[15] or with princes who had gold, who filled their houses with silver.
[16] Or why was I not hidden like a stillborn child, like an infant who never sees daylight?
[17] There the wicked cease from raging, and there the weary find rest.
[18] The captives enjoy their ease; they do not hear the voice of the oppressor.
[19] Both small and great are there, and the slave is freed from his master.
[20] Why is light given to the miserable, and life to the bitter of soul,
[21] who long for death that does not come, and search for it like hidden treasure,
[22] who rejoice and greatly exult when they can find the grave?
[23] Why is life given to a man whose way is hidden, whom God has hedged in?
[24] I sigh when food is put before me, and my groans pour out like water.
[25] For the thing I feared has overtaken me, and what I dreaded has befallen me.
[26] "I am not at ease or quiet; I have no rest, for trouble has come."

4 Then Eliphaz the Temanite replied:
[2] "If one ventures a word with you, will you be wearied? Yet who can keep from speaking?"
[3] Surely you have instructed many, and have strengthened their feeble hands.
[4] Your words have steadied those who stumbled; you have braced the knees that were buckling.
[5] But now trouble has come upon you, and you are weary. It strikes you, and you are dismayed.
[6] Is your reverence not your confidence, and the uprightness of your ways your hope?
[7] Consider now, I plead: Who, being innocent, has ever perished? Or where have the upright been destroyed?
[8] As I have observed, those who plow iniquity and those who sow trouble reap the same.
[9] By the breath of God they perish, and by the blast of His anger they are consumed.
[10] The lion may roar, and the fierce lion may growl, yet the teeth of the young lions are broken.
[11] The old lion perishes for lack of prey, and the cubs of the lioness are scattered.
[12] Now a word came to me secretly; my ears caught a whisper of it.
[13] In disquieting visions in the night, when deep sleep falls on men,
[14] fear and trembling came over me and made all my bones shudder.
[15] Then a spirit glided past my face, and the hair on my body bristled.
[16] It stood still, but I could not discern its appearance; a form loomed before my eyes, and I heard a whispering voice:
[17] 'Can a mortal be more righteous than God, or a man more pure than his Maker?'
[18] If God puts no trust in His servants, and He charges His angels with error,
[19] how much more those who dwell in houses of clay, whose foundations are in the dust, who can be crushed like a moth!
[20] They are smashed to pieces from dawn to dusk; unnoticed, they perish forever.
[21] Are not their tent cords pulled up, so that they die without wisdom?'

5 "Call out if you please, but who will answer? To which of the holy ones will you turn?"

[2] For resentment kills a fool, and envy slays the simple.
[3] I have seen a fool taking root, but suddenly his house was cursed.
[4] His sons are far from safety, crushed in court without a defender.
[5] The hungry consume his harvest, taking it even from the thorns, and the thirsty pant after his wealth.
[6] For distress does not spring from the dust, and trouble does not sprout from the ground.
[7] Yet man is born to trouble as surely as sparks fly upward.
[8] However, if I were you, I would appeal to God and lay my cause before Him—
[9] the One who does great and unsearchable things, wonders without number.
[10] He gives rain to the earth and sends water upon the fields.
[11] He sets the lowly on high, so that mourners are lifted to safety.
[12] He thwarts the schemes of the crafty, so that their hands find no success.
[13] He catches the wise in their craftiness, and sweeps away the plans of the cunning.
[14] They encounter darkness by day and grope at noon as in the night.
[15] He saves the needy from the sword in their mouth and from the clutches of the powerful.
[16] So the poor have hope, and injustice shuts its mouth.
[17] Blessed indeed is the man whom God corrects; so do not despise the discipline of the Almighty.
[18] For He wounds, but He also binds; He strikes, but His hands also heal.
[19] He will rescue you from six calamities; no harm will touch you in seven.
[20] In famine He will redeem you from death, and in battle from the stroke of the sword.
[21] You will be hidden from the scourge of the tongue, and will not fear havoc when it comes.
[22] You will laugh at destruction and famine, and need not fear the beasts of the earth.
[23] For you will have a covenant with the stones of the field, and the wild animals will be at peace with you.
[24] You will know that your tent is secure, and find nothing amiss when inspecting your home.
[25] You will know that your offspring will be many, your descendants like the grass of the earth.
[26] You will come to the grave in full vigor, like a sheaf of grain gathered in season.
[27] "Indeed, we have investigated, and it is true! So hear it and know for yourself."

6 Then Job replied:
[2] "If only my grief could be weighed and placed with my calamity on the scales."
[3] For then it would outweigh the sand of the seas— no wonder my words have been rash.
[4] For the arrows of the Almighty have pierced me; my spirit drinks in their poison; the terrors of God are arrayed against me.
[5] Does a wild donkey bray over fresh grass, or an ox low over its fodder?
[6] Is tasteless food eaten without salt, or is there flavor in the white of an egg?
[7] My soul refuses to touch them; they are loathsome food to me.
[8] If only my request were granted and God would fulfill my hope:
[9] that God would be willing to crush me, to unleash His hand and cut me off!
[10] It still brings me comfort, and joy through unrelenting pain, that I have not denied the words of the Holy One.
[11] What strength do I have, that I should still hope? What is my future, that I should be patient?
[12] Is my strength like that of stone, or my flesh made of bronze?
[13] Is there any help within me now that success is driven from me?
[14] A despairing man should have the kindness of his friend, even if he forsakes the fear of the Almighty.
[15] But my brothers are as faithless as wadis, as seasonal streams that overflow,
[16] darkened because of the ice and the inflow of melting snow,
[17] but ceasing in the dry season and vanishing from their channels in the heat.
[18] Caravans turn aside from their routes; they go into the wasteland and perish.
[19] The caravans of Tema look for water; the travelers of Sheba hope to find it.
[20] They are confounded because they had hoped; their arrival brings disappointment.
[21] For now you are of no help; you see terror, and you are afraid.
[22] Have I ever said, 'Give me something; offer me a bribe from your wealth;'
[23] deliver me from the hand of the enemy; redeem me from the grasp of the ruthless'?
[24] Teach me, and I will be silent. Help me understand how I have erred.
[25] How painful are honest words! But what does your argument prove?
[26] Do you intend to correct my words, and treat as wind my cry of despair?
[27] You would even cast lots for an orphan and barter away your friend.
[28] But now, please look at me. Would I lie to your face?
[29] Reconsider; do not be unjust. Reconsider, for my righteousness is at stake.
[30] Is there iniquity on my tongue? Can my mouth not discern malice?

7 "Is not man consigned to labor on earth? Are not his days like those of a hired hand?"
[2] Like a slave he longs for shade; like a hireling he waits for his wages.
[3] So I am allotted months of futility, and nights of misery are appointed me.
[4] When I lie down I think: 'When will I get up?' But the night drags on, and I toss and turn until dawn.
[5] My flesh is clothed with worms and encrusted with dirt; my skin is cracked and festering.
[6] My days are swifter than a weaver's shuttle; they come to an end without hope.
[7] Remember that my life is but a breath. My eyes will never again see happiness.
[8] The eye that beholds me will no longer see me. You will look for me, but I will be no more.
[9] As a cloud vanishes and is gone, so he who goes down to Sheol does not come back up.
[10] He never returns to his house; his place remembers him no more.
[11] Therefore I will not restrain my mouth; I will speak in the anguish of my spirit; I will complain in the bitterness of my soul.
[12] Am I the sea, or the monster of the deep, that You must keep me under guard?
[13] When I think my bed will comfort me and my couch will ease my complaint,
[14] then You frighten me with dreams and terrify me with visions,
[15] so that I would prefer strangling and death over my life in this body.
[16] I loathe my life! I would not live forever. Leave me alone, for my days are but a breath.
[17] What is man that You should exalt him, that You should set Your heart upon him,
[18] that You attend to him every morning, and test him every moment?
[19] Will You never look away from me, or leave me alone to swallow my spittle?
[20] If I have sinned, what have I done to You, O watcher of mankind? Why have You made me Your target, so that I am a burden to You?
[21] "Why do You not pardon my transgression and take away my iniquity? For soon I will lie down in the dust; You will seek me, but I will be no more."

8 Then Bildad the Shuhite replied:
[2] "How long will you go on saying such things? The words of your mouth are a blustering wind."
[3] Does God pervert justice? Does the Almighty pervert what is right?
[4] When your children sinned against Him, He gave them over to their rebellion.
[5] But if you would earnestly seek God and ask the Almighty for mercy,
[6] if you are pure and upright, even now He will rouse Himself on your behalf and restore your righteous estate.
[7] Though your beginnings were modest, your latter days will flourish.
[8] Please inquire of past generations and consider the discoveries of their fathers.
[9] For we were born yesterday and know nothing; our days on earth are but a shadow.
[10] Will they not teach you and tell you, and speak from their understanding?
[11] Does papyrus grow where there is no marsh? Do reeds flourish without water?
[12] While the shoots are still uncut, they dry up quicker than grass.
[13] Such is the destiny of all who forget God; so the hope of the godless will perish.
[14] His confidence is fragile; his security is in a spider's web.
[15] He leans on his web, but it gives way; he holds fast, but it does not endure.
[16] He is a well-watered plant in the sunshine, spreading its shoots over the garden.
[17] His roots wrap around the rock heap; he looks for a home among the stones.
[18] If he is uprooted from his place, it will disown him, saying, 'I never saw you.'
[19] Surely this is the joy of his way; yet others will spring from the dust.
[20] Behold, God does not reject the blameless, nor will He strengthen the hand of evildoers.
[21] He will yet fill your mouth with laughter, and your lips with a shout of joy.
[22] "Your enemies will be clothed in shame, and the tent of the wicked will be no more."

9 Then Job answered:
[2] "Yes, I know that it is so, but how can a mortal be righteous before God?"
[3] If one wished to contend with God, he could not answer Him one time out of a thousand.
[4] God is wise in heart and mighty in strength. Who has resisted Him and prospered?
[5] He moves mountains without their knowledge and overturns them in His anger.
[6] He shakes the earth from its place, so that its foundations tremble.
[7] He commands the sun not to shine; He seals off the stars.
[8] He alone stretches out the heavens and treads on the waves of the sea.
[9] He is the Maker of the Bear and Orion, of the Pleiades and the constellations of the south.
[10] He does great things beyond searching out, and wonders without number.
[11] Were He to pass by me, I would not see Him; were He to move, I would not recognize Him.
[12] If He takes away, who can stop Him? Who dares to ask Him, 'What are You doing?'
[13] God does not restrain His anger; the helpers of Rahab cower beneath Him.
[14] How then can I answer Him or choose my arguments against Him?
[15] For even if I were right, I could not answer. I could only beg my Judge for mercy.
[16] If I summoned Him and He answered me, I do not believe He would listen to my voice.
[17] For He would crush me with a tempest and multiply my wounds without cause.

18 He does not let me catch my breath, but overwhelms me with bitterness.
19 If it is a matter of strength, He is indeed mighty! If it is a matter of justice, who can summon Him?
20 Even if I were righteous, my mouth would condemn me; if I were blameless, it would declare me guilty.
21 Though I am blameless, I have no concern for myself; I despise my own life.
22 It is all the same, and so I say, 'He destroys both the blameless and the wicked.'
23 When the scourge brings sudden death, He mocks the despair of the innocent.
24 The earth is given into the hand of the wicked; He blindfolds its judges. If it is not He, then who is it?
25 My days are swifter than a runner; they flee without seeing good.
26 They sweep by like boats of papyrus, like an eagle swooping down on its prey.
27 If I were to say, 'I will forget my complaint and change my expression and smile,'
28 I would still dread all my sufferings; I know that You will not acquit me.
29 Since I am already found guilty, why should I labor in vain?
30 If I should wash myself with snow and cleanse my hands with lye,
31 then You would plunge me into the pit, and even my own clothes would despise me.
32 For He is not a man like me, that I can answer Him, that we can take each other to court.
33 Nor is there a mediator between us, to lay his hand upon us both.
34 Let Him remove His rod from me, so that His terror will no longer frighten me.
35 Then I would speak without fear of Him. But as it is, I am on my own.

10 "I loathe my own life; I will express my complaint and speak in the bitterness of my soul."
2 I will say to God: Do not condemn me! Let me know why You prosecute me.
3 Does it please You to oppress me, to reject the work of Your hands and favor the schemes of the wicked?
4 Do You have eyes of flesh? Do You see as man sees?
5 Are Your days like those of a mortal, or Your years like those of a man,
6 that You should seek my iniquity and search out my sin—
7 though You know that I am not guilty, and there is no deliverance from Your hand?
8 Your hands shaped me and altogether formed me. Would You now turn and destroy me?
9 Please remember that You molded me like clay. Would You now return me to dust?
10 Did You not pour me out like milk, and curdle me like cheese?
11 You clothed me with skin and flesh, and knit me together with bones and sinews.
12 You have granted me life and loving devotion, and Your care has preserved my spirit.
13 Yet You concealed these things in Your heart, and I know that this was in Your mind:
14 If I sinned, You would take note, and would not acquit me of my iniquity.
15 If I am guilty, woe to me! And even if I am righteous, I cannot lift my head. I am full of shame and aware of my affliction.
16 Should I hold my head high, You would hunt me like a lion, and again display Your power against me.
17 You produce new witnesses against me and multiply Your anger toward me. Hardships assault me in wave after wave.
18 Why then did You bring me from the womb? Oh, that I had died, and no eye had seen me!
19 If only I had never come to be, but had been carried from the womb to the grave.
20 Are my days not few? Withdraw from me, that I may have a little comfort,
21 before I go—never to return— to a land of darkness and gloom,
22 "to a land of utter darkness, of deep shadow and disorder, where even the light is like darkness."

11 Then Zophar the Naamathite replied:
2 "Should this stream of words go unanswered and such a speaker be vindicated?"
3 Should your babbling put others to silence? Will you scoff without rebuke?
4 You have said, 'My doctrine is sound, and I am pure in Your sight.'
5 But if only God would speak and open His lips against you,
6 and disclose to you the secrets of wisdom, for true wisdom has two sides. Know then that God exacts from you less than your iniquity deserves.
7 Can you fathom the deep things of God or discover the limits of the Almighty?
8 They are higher than the heavens—what can you do? They are deeper than Sheol—what can you know?
9 Their measure is longer than the earth and wider than the sea.
10 If He comes along to imprison you, or convenes a court, who can stop Him?
11 Surely He knows the deceit of men. If He sees iniquity, does He not take note?
12 But a witless man can no more become wise than the colt of a wild donkey can be born a man!
13 As for you, if you direct your heart and lift up your hands to Him,
14 if you put away the iniquity in your hand, and allow no injustice to dwell in your tents,
15 then indeed you will lift up your face without shame; you will stand firm and unafraid.
16 For you will forget your misery, recalling it only as waters gone by.
17 Your life will be brighter than noonday; its darkness will be like the morning.
18 You will be secure, because there is hope, and you will look around and lie down in safety.
19 You will lie down without fear, and many will court your favor.
20 "But the eyes of the wicked will fail, and escape will elude them; they will hope for their last breath."

12 Then Job answered:
2 "Truly then you are the people with whom wisdom itself will die!"
3 But I also have a mind; I am not inferior to you. Who does not know such things as these?
4 I am a laughingstock to my friends, though I called on God, and He answered. The righteous and upright man is a laughingstock.
5 The one at ease scorns misfortune as the fate of those whose feet are slipping.
6 The tents of robbers are safe, and those who provoke God are secure— those who carry their god in their hands.
7 But ask the animals, and they will instruct you; ask the birds of the air, and they will tell you.
8 Or speak to the earth, and it will teach you; let the fish of the sea inform you.
9 Which of all these does not know that the hand of the LORD has done this?
10 The life of every living thing is in His hand, as well as the breath of all mankind.
11 Does not the ear test words as the tongue tastes its food?
12 Wisdom is found with the elderly, and understanding comes with long life.
13 Wisdom and strength belong to God; counsel and understanding are His.
14 What He tears down cannot be rebuilt; the man He imprisons cannot be released.
15 If He holds back the waters, they dry up, and if He releases them, they overwhelm the land.
16 True wisdom and power belong to Him. The deceived and the deceiver are His.
17 He leads counselors away barefoot and makes fools of judges.
18 He loosens the bonds placed by kings and fastens a belt around their waists.
19 He leads priests away barefoot and overthrows the established.
20 He deprives the trusted of speech and takes away the discernment of elders.
21 He pours out contempt on nobles and disarms the mighty.
22 He reveals the deep things of darkness and brings deep shadows into light.
23 He makes nations great and destroys them; He enlarges nations, then disperses them.
24 He deprives the earth's leaders of reason and makes them wander in a trackless wasteland.
25 They grope in the darkness without light; He makes them stagger like drunkards.

13 "Indeed, my eyes have seen all this; my ears have heard and understood."
2 What you know, I also know; I am not inferior to you.
3 Yet I desire to speak to the Almighty and argue my case before God.
4 You, however, smear with lies; you are all worthless physicians.
5 If only you would remain silent; for that would be your wisdom!
6 Hear now my argument, and listen to the plea of my lips.
7 Will you speak wickedly on God's behalf or speak deceitfully for Him?
8 Would you show Him partiality or argue in His defense?
9 Would it be well when He examined you? Could you deceive Him like a man?
10 Surely He would rebuke you if you secretly showed partiality.
11 Would His majesty not terrify you? Would the dread of Him not fall upon you?
12 Your maxims are proverbs of ashes; your defenses are defenses of clay.
13 Be silent, and I will speak. Then let come to me what may.
14 Why do I put myself at risk and take my life in my own hands?
15 Though He slay me, I will hope in Him. I will still defend my ways to His face.
16 Moreover, this will be my salvation, for no godless man can appear before Him.
17 Listen carefully to my words; let my declaration ring in your ears.
18 Behold, now that I have prepared my case, I know that I will be vindicated.
19 Can anyone indict me? If so, I will be silent and die.
20 Only grant these two things to me, so that I need not hide from You:
21 Withdraw Your hand from me, and do not let Your terror frighten me.
22 Then call me, and I will answer, or let me speak, and You can reply.
23 How many are my iniquities and sins? Reveal to me my transgression and sin.
24 Why do You hide Your face and consider me as Your enemy?
25 Would You frighten a windblown leaf? Would You chase after dry chaff?
26 For You record bitter accusations against me and bequeath to me the iniquities of my youth.
27 You put my feet in the stocks and stand watch over all my paths; You set a limit for the soles of my feet.
28 So man wastes away like something rotten, like a moth-eaten garment.

14 "Man, who is born of woman, is short of days and full of trouble."
2 Like a flower, he comes forth, then withers away; like a fleeting shadow, he does not endure.
3 Do You open Your eyes to one like this? Will You bring him into judgment before You?

[4] Who can bring out clean from unclean? No one!
[5] Since his days are determined and the number of his months is with You, and since You have set limits that he cannot exceed,
[6] look away from him and let him rest, so he can enjoy his day as a hired hand.
[7] For there is hope for a tree: If it is cut down, it will sprout again, and its tender shoots will not fail.
[8] If its roots grow old in the ground and its stump dies in the soil,
[9] at the scent of water it will bud and put forth twigs like a sapling.
[10] But a man dies and is laid low; he breathes his last, and where is he?
[11] As water disappears from the sea and a river becomes parched and dry,
[12] so a man lies down and does not rise. Until the heavens are no more, he will not be awakened or roused from sleep.
[13] If only You would hide me in Sheol and conceal me until Your anger has passed! If only You would appoint a time for me and then remember me!
[14] When a man dies, will he live again? All the days of my hard service I will wait, until my renewal comes.
[15] You will call, and I will answer; You will desire the work of Your hands.
[16] For then You would count my steps, but would not keep track of my sin.
[17] My transgression would be sealed in a bag, and You would cover over my iniquity.
[18] But as a mountain erodes and crumbles and a rock is dislodged from its place,
[19] as water wears away the stones and torrents wash away the soil, so You destroy a man's hope.
[20] You forever overpower him, and he passes on; You change his countenance and send him away.
[21] If his sons receive honor, he does not know it; if they are brought low, he is unaware.
[22] "He feels only the pain of his own body and mourns only for himself."

15 Then Eliphaz the Temanite replied:
[2] "Does a wise man answer with empty counsel or fill his belly with the hot east wind?"
[3] Should he argue with useless words or speeches that serve no purpose?
[4] But you even undermine the fear of God and hinder meditation before Him.
[5] For your iniquity instructs your mouth, and you choose the language of the crafty.
[6] Your own mouth, not mine, condemns you; your own lips testify against you.
[7] Were you the first man ever born? Were you brought forth before the hills?
[8] Do you listen in on the council of God or limit wisdom to yourself?
[9] What do you know that we do not? What do you understand that is not clear to us?
[10] Both the gray-haired and the aged are on our side— men much older than your father.
[11] Are the consolations of God not enough for you, even words spoken gently to you?
[12] Why has your heart carried you away, and why do your eyes flash,
[13] as you turn your spirit against God and pour such words from your mouth?
[14] What is man, that he should be pure, or one born of woman, that he should be righteous?
[15] If God puts no trust in His holy ones, if even the heavens are not pure in His eyes,
[16] how much less man, who is vile and corrupt, who drinks injustice like water?
[17] Listen to me and I will inform you. I will describe what I have seen,
[18] what was declared by wise men and was not concealed from their fathers,
[19] to whom alone the land was given when no foreigner passed among them.
[20] A wicked man writhes in pain all his days; only a few years are reserved for the ruthless.
[21] Sounds of terror fill his ears; in his prosperity the destroyer attacks him.
[22] He despairs of his return from darkness; he is marked for the sword.
[23] He wanders about as food for vultures; he knows the day of darkness is at hand.
[24] Distress and anguish terrify him, overwhelming him like a king poised to attack.
[25] For he has stretched out his hand against God and has vaunted himself against the Almighty,
[26] rushing headlong at Him with a thick, studded shield.
[27] Though his face is covered with fat and his waistline bulges with flesh,
[28] he will dwell in ruined cities, in abandoned houses destined to become rubble.
[29] He will no longer be rich; his wealth will not endure. His possessions will not overspread the land.
[30] He will not escape from the darkness; the flame will wither his shoots, and the breath of God's mouth will carry him away.
[31] Let him not deceive himself with trust in emptiness, for emptiness will be his reward.
[32] It will be paid in full before his time, and his branch will not flourish.
[33] He will be like a vine stripped of its unripe grapes, like an olive tree that sheds its blossoms.
[34] For the company of the godless will be barren, and fire will consume the tents of bribery.
[35] "They conceive trouble and give birth to evil; their womb is pregnant with deceit."

16 Then Job answered:
[2] "I have heard many things like these; miserable comforters are you all."
[3] Is there no end to your long-winded speeches? What provokes you to continue testifying?
[4] I could also speak like you if you were in my place; I could heap up words against you and shake my head at you.
[5] But I would encourage you with my mouth, and the consolation of my lips would bring relief.
[6] Even if I speak, my pain is not relieved, and if I hold back, how will it go away?
[7] Surely He has now exhausted me; You have devastated all my family.
[8] You have bound me, and it has become a witness; my frailty rises up and testifies against me.
[9] His anger has torn me and opposed me; He gnashes His teeth at me. My adversary pierces me with His eyes.
[10] They open their mouths against me and strike my cheeks with contempt; they join together against me.
[11] God has delivered me to unjust men; He has thrown me to the clutches of the wicked.
[12] I was at ease, but He shattered me; He seized me by the neck and crushed me. He has set me up as His target;
[13] His archers surround me. He pierces my kidneys without mercy and spills my gall on the ground.
[14] He breaks me with wound upon wound; He rushes me like a mighty warrior.
[15] I have sewn sackcloth over my skin; I have buried my horn in the dust.
[16] My face is red with weeping, and deep shadows ring my eyes;
[17] yet my hands are free of violence and my prayer is pure.
[18] O earth, do not cover my blood; may my cry for help never be laid to rest.
[19] Even now my witness is in heaven, and my advocate is on high.
[20] My friends are my scoffers as my eyes pour out tears to God.
[21] Oh, that a man might plead with God as he pleads with his neighbor!
[22] For when only a few years are past I will go the way of no return.

17 "My spirit is broken; my days are extinguished; the grave awaits me."
[2] Surely mockers surround me, and my eyes must gaze at their rebellion.
[3] Give me, I pray, the pledge You demand. Who else will be my guarantor?
[4] You have closed their minds to understanding; therefore You will not exalt them.
[5] If a man denounces his friends for a price, the eyes of his children will fail.
[6] He has made me a byword among the people, a man in whose face they spit.
[7] My eyes have grown dim with grief, and my whole body is but a shadow.
[8] The upright are appalled at this, and the innocent are stirred against the godless.
[9] Yet a righteous one holds to his way, and the one with clean hands grows stronger.
[10] But come back and try again, all of you. For I will not find a wise man among you.
[11] My days have passed; my plans are broken off— even the desires of my heart.
[12] They have turned night into day, making light seem near in the face of darkness.
[13] If I look for Sheol as my home, if I spread out my bed in darkness,
[14] and say to corruption, 'You are my father,' and to the worm, 'My mother,' or 'My sister,'
[15] where then is my hope? Who can see any hope for me?
[16] "Will it go down to the gates of Sheol? Will we go down together into the dust?"

18 Then Bildad the Shuhite replied:
[2] "How long until you end these speeches? Show some sense, and then we can talk."
[3] Why are we regarded as cattle, as stupid in your sight?
[4] You who tear yourself in anger— should the earth be forsaken on your account, or the rocks be moved from their place?
[5] Indeed, the lamp of the wicked is extinguished; the flame of his fire does not glow.
[6] The light in his tent grows dark, and the lamp beside him goes out.
[7] His vigorous stride is shortened, and his own schemes trip him up.
[8] For his own feet lead him into a net, and he wanders into its mesh.
[9] A trap seizes his heel; a snare grips him.
[10] A noose is hidden in the ground, and a trap lies in his path.
[11] Terrors frighten him on every side and harass his every step.
[12] His strength is depleted, and calamity is ready at his side.
[13] It devours patches of his skin; the firstborn of death devours his limbs.
[14] He is torn from the shelter of his tent and is marched off to the king of terrors.
[15] Fire resides in his tent; burning sulfur rains down on his dwelling.
[16] The roots beneath him dry up, and the branches above him wither away.
[17] The memory of him perishes from the earth, and he has no name in the land.
[18] He is driven from light into darkness and is chased from the inhabited world.
[19] He has no offspring or posterity among his people, no survivor where he once lived.
[20] Those in the west are appalled at his fate, while those in the east tremble in horror.
[21] "Surely such is the dwelling of the wicked and the place of one who does not know God."

19 Then Job answered:
2 "How long will you torment me and crush me with your words?"
3 Ten times now you have reproached me; you shamelessly mistreat me.
4 Even if I have truly gone astray, my error concerns me alone.
5 If indeed you would exalt yourselves above me and use my disgrace against me,
6 then understand that it is God who has wronged me and drawn His net around me.
7 Though I cry out, 'Violence!' I get no response; though I call for help, there is no justice.
8 He has blocked my way so I cannot pass; He has veiled my paths with darkness.
9 He has stripped me of my honor and removed the crown from my head.
10 He tears me down on every side until I am gone; He uproots my hope like a tree.
11 His anger burns against me, and He counts me among His enemies.
12 His troops advance together; they construct a ramp against me and encamp around my tent.
13 He has removed my brothers from me; my acquaintances have abandoned me.
14 My kinsmen have failed me, and my friends have forgotten me.
15 My guests and maidservants count me as a stranger; I am a foreigner in their sight.
16 I call for my servant, but he does not answer, though I implore him with my own mouth.
17 My breath is repulsive to my wife, and I am loathsome to my own family.
18 Even little boys scorn me; when I appear, they deride me.
19 All my best friends despise me, and those I love have turned against me.
20 My skin and flesh cling to my bones; I have escaped by the skin of my teeth.
21 Have pity on me, my friends, have pity, for the hand of God has struck me.
22 Why do you persecute me as God does? Will you never get enough of my flesh?
23 I wish that my words were recorded and inscribed in a book,
24 by an iron stylus on lead, or chiseled in stone forever.
25 But I know that my Redeemer lives, and in the end He will stand upon the earth.
26 Even after my skin has been destroyed, yet in my flesh I will see God.
27 I will see Him for myself; my eyes will behold Him, and not as a stranger. How my heart yearns within me!
28 If you say, 'Let us persecute him, since the root of the matter lies with him,'
29 "then you should fear the sword yourselves, because wrath brings punishment by the sword, so that you may know there is a judgment."

20 Then Zophar the Naamathite replied:
2 "So my anxious thoughts compel me to answer, because of the turmoil within me."
3 I have heard a rebuke that insults me, and my understanding prompts a reply.
4 Do you not know that from antiquity, since man was placed on the earth,
5 the triumph of the wicked has been brief and the joy of the godless momentary?
6 Though his arrogance reaches the heavens, and his head touches the clouds,
7 he will perish forever, like his own dung; those who had seen him will ask, 'Where is he?'
8 He will fly away like a dream, never to be found; he will be chased away like a vision in the night.
9 The eye that saw him will see him no more, and his place will no longer behold him.
10 His sons will seek the favor of the poor, for his own hands must return his wealth.
11 The youthful vigor that fills his bones will lie down with him in the dust.
12 Though evil is sweet in his mouth and he conceals it under his tongue,
13 though he cannot bear to let it go and keeps it in his mouth,
14 yet in his stomach his food sours into the venom of cobras within him.
15 He swallows wealth but vomits it out; God will force it from his stomach.
16 He will suck the poison of cobras; the fangs of a viper will kill him.
17 He will not enjoy the streams, the rivers flowing with honey and cream.
18 He must return the fruit of his labor without consuming it; he cannot enjoy the profits of his trading.
19 For he has oppressed and forsaken the poor; he has seized houses he did not build.
20 Because his appetite is never satisfied, he cannot escape with his treasure.
21 Nothing is left for him to consume; thus his prosperity will not endure.
22 In the midst of his plenty, he will be distressed; the full force of misery will come upon him.
23 When he has filled his stomach, God will vent His fury upon him, raining it down on him as he eats.
24 Though he flees from an iron weapon, a bronze-tipped arrow will pierce him.
25 It is drawn out of his back, the gleaming point from his liver. Terrors come over him.
26 Total darkness is reserved for his treasures. A fire unfanned will consume him and devour what is left in his tent.
27 The heavens will expose his iniquity, and the earth will rise up against him.
28 The possessions of his house will be removed, flowing away on the day of God's wrath.
29 "This is the wicked man's portion from God, the inheritance God has appointed him."

21 Then Job answered:
2 "Listen carefully to my words; let this be your consolation to me."
3 Bear with me while I speak; then, after I have spoken, you may go on mocking.
4 Is my complaint against a man? Then why should I not be impatient?
5 Look at me and be appalled; put your hand over your mouth.
6 When I remember, terror takes hold, and my body trembles in horror.
7 Why do the wicked live on, growing old and increasing in power?
8 Their descendants are established around them, and their offspring before their eyes.
9 Their homes are safe from fear; no rod of punishment from God is upon them.
10 Their bulls breed without fail; their cows bear calves and do not miscarry.
11 They send forth their little ones like a flock; their children skip about,
12 singing to the tambourine and lyre and making merry at the sound of the flute.
13 They spend their days in prosperity and go down to Sheol in peace.
14 Yet they say to God: 'Leave us alone! For we have no desire to know Your ways.'
15 Who is the Almighty, that we should serve Him, and what would we gain if we pray to Him?'
16 Still, their prosperity is not in their own hands, so I stay far from the counsel of the wicked.
17 How often is the lamp of the wicked put out? Does disaster come upon them? Does God, in His anger, apportion destruction?
18 Are they like straw before the wind, like chaff swept away by a storm?
19 It is said that God lays up one's punishment for his children. Let God repay the man himself, so he will know it.
20 Let his eyes see his own destruction; let him drink for himself the wrath of the Almighty.
21 For what does he care about his household after him, when the number of his months has run out?
22 Can anyone teach knowledge to God, since He judges those on high?
23 One man dies full of vigor, completely secure and at ease.
24 His body is well nourished, and his bones are rich with marrow.
25 Yet another man dies in the bitterness of his soul, having never tasted prosperity.
26 But together they lie down in the dust, and worms cover them both.
27 Behold, I know your thoughts full well, the schemes by which you would wrong me.
28 For you say, 'Where now is the nobleman's house, and where are the tents in which the wicked dwell?'
29 Have you never asked those who travel the roads? Do you not accept their reports?
30 Indeed, the evil man is spared from the day of calamity, delivered from the day of wrath.
31 Who denounces his behavior to his face? Who repays him for what he has done?
32 He is carried to the grave, and watch is kept over his tomb.
33 The clods of the valley are sweet to him; everyone follows behind him, and those before him are without number.
34 "So how can you comfort me with empty words? For your answers remain full of falsehood."

22 Then Eliphaz the Temanite replied:
2 "Can a man be of use to God? Can even a wise man benefit Him?"
3 Does it delight the Almighty that you are righteous? Does He profit if your ways are blameless?
4 Is it for your reverence that He rebukes you and enters into judgment against you?
5 Is not your wickedness great? Are not your iniquities endless?
6 For you needlessly demanded security from your brothers and deprived the naked of their clothing.
7 You gave no water to the weary and withheld food from the famished,
8 while the land belonged to a mighty man, and a man of honor lived on it.
9 You sent widows away empty-handed, and the strength of the fatherless was crushed.
10 Therefore snares surround you, and sudden peril terrifies you;
11 it is so dark you cannot see, and a flood of water covers you.
12 Is not God as high as the heavens? Look at the highest stars, how lofty they are!
13 Yet you say: 'What does God know? Does He judge through thick darkness?'
14 Thick clouds veil Him so He does not see us as He traverses the vault of heaven.'
15 Will you stay on the ancient path that wicked men have trod?

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